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PROJECT 3 · BRIEF-TO-OUTPUT CASE STUDY

From one-line brief to a full campaign system.

"We're a small-batch D2C coffee brand. Launch our limited-edition dark roast to people who buy coffee at midnight. Playful, but premium. Make it feel scarce."

FICTIONAL CLIENT BRIEF · ROAST THEORY® · DELIVERABLES: SOCIAL + DISPLAY

The insight I chose to build on

Midnight coffee buyers aren't buying caffeine — they're buying **permission to stay up**. So instead of advertising the coffee, the campaign advertises the moment: 1 a.m., quiet, yours. That gave me the creative platform — **"For the 1 a.m. crowd"** — and a visual metaphor the whole system hangs on: a **crema-colored full moon** that reads as moon, coffee lid, and crema in one shape.

Two directions I killed (and why)

DIRECTION A · REJECTED

DIRECTION B · REJECTED

"Bean There" — bright & illustrated

Pastel palette, wavy retro type, smiling bean mascot. The obvious "fun coffee brand" move.

WHY IT DIED

Looked like every D2C coffee brand on Instagram. Zero scarcity — scarcity needs night, and this palette was a sunny café. Premium and playful don't survive pastels.

"Roast Index" — technical & swiss

Monospace data-viz, tasting-note charts, grid everything. Very clever, very cold.

WHY IT DIED

Appealed to coffee nerds but excluded the casual 1 a.m. buyer. Emotion was missing — and emotional recall is what makes an ad work at midnight when nobody's comparison-shopping.

The winning direction: "Midnight Roast"

Dark, warm, and scarce — the night sky does the selling.

Near-black grounds the premium feel; crema-tan and burnt orange keep it warm, not gloomy. One repeated shape — the crema moon — makes 7 formats read as one brand. Scarcity is built into the copy everywhere: **500 bags, then it's gone.**

INK · 16130F

CREMA · F4EAD8

LATTE · D9B98C

BURNT · C96F3B

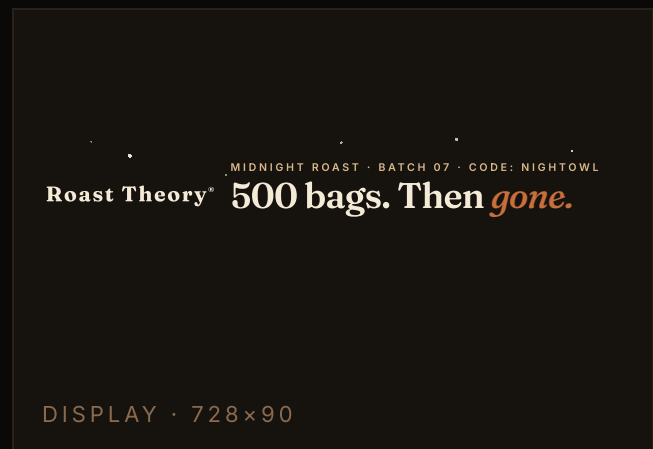
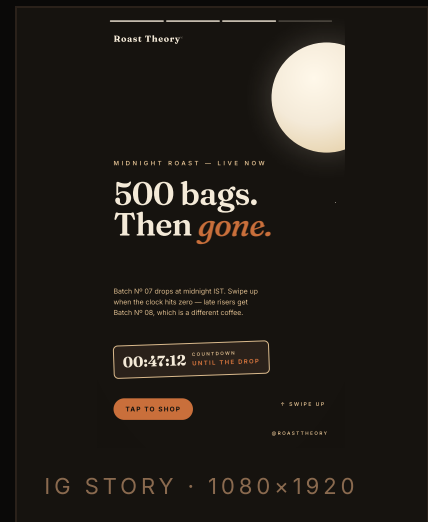
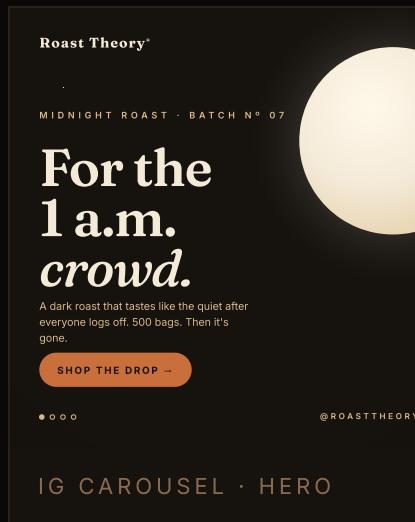
TYPE & MOTIF

Fraunces — for the voice. *Italic serif for the punchline.*

Inter — for everything the voice needs to be legible: eyebrows, offers, CTAs.
One shape rules the system: **the crema moon**.

Final outputs — one campaign, four formats

Every piece keeps the same headline language, the moon, and the offer. Format changes the layout, never the brand.



What I'd carry into the next brief

- **One metaphor beats ten ideas.** The crema moon made every resize decision obvious — if it's not the moon's moment, the format doesn't need it.
- **Scarcity is a design constraint.** "500 bags" shaped the palette (night), the type (urgent italics), and the CTA (Shop the drop) — not just the copy.
- **Design for the smallest unit first.** The 160×600 forced the message down to five words; if it works there, it works everywhere.